

"If you want excellence, you must aim at perfect

STEEL IN HIS SPINE

His dream was that private enterprise and public enterprise be the two wheels that should take India forward. He also envisaged an aviation boom, kickstarted an engineering revolution and supported a spate of institutions.

■ By R.M. Lala

J.R.D. Tata's life spanned almost the entire 20th century. He was born soon after the Wright Brothers made their first flight, and lived to see Manmohan Singh introduce liberalisation in 1991. In 1932, when aviation was a rich man's toy, he launched Tata Airlines. A hundred days later, speaking at the Rotary Club, he said that a day would come when one would not think of travelling by any other means than air. We are just witnessing the boom in aviation he foresaw 75 years ago.

When the Nazis were inflicting atrocities on the world, he was thinking about how to take India forward after the war. He called together top industrialists like G.D. Birla, Kasturbhai Lalbhai and others which resulted in the Bombay Plan. In 1945, he started TELCO, originally for engineering and locomotives. It was his vision to set up a great engineering company for India. With the launch of a Rs 1-lakh people's car Nano by his successor as chairman of Tata Sons, Ratan Tata, in January, the world has woken up to the real potential of the company he started.

In 1948, he started Air India International, the first Asian airline to fly to the West. He proposed that the Union government partner with the Tatas. And they did. His dream was that private enterprise and public enterprise would be the two wheels that would take India forward. Alas, soon the virus of state capitalism had entered into Nehru's thinking and Air India International was the first and

last venture of its kind. Thereafter, Nehru and his daughter, Indira, respected JRD for his competence at aviation and valued him as a friend but due to differences in ideology, Nehru never consulted him on Indian economy and industrialisation.

When I said to him that Nehru's death was the end of an era for India, JRD replied, "And for me too. I was very fond of him." In the licence-permit raj, the Tatas would not manipulate and though they grew, their growth was not as spectacular as that of newer groups. In 1979, when I asked him about it he said, "I have often thought of it. Had we adopted some of the means that others did, we would have been twice as big as we are today. But we wouldn't want it any other way."

On the management side he was proud that he had dealt with a hundred directors in his lifetime making allowances for their idiosyncrasies to get the best out of them. He said: "To lead men you have to lead them with affection." A year after he died, I told Ratan: "I don't miss him as my chairman but I do miss his affection." Ratan replied: "So do I."

Few realise that when Homi Bhabha was stranded in India as the Second World War broke out, JRD had a special Department of Cosmic Energy started in Bangalore at the Indian Institute of Science so that Bhabha could continue his work which he did at Cambridge. Four years later, he had the vision to support Bhabha's plan for a Tata Institute of Fundamental Research, which became, as Bhabha said,

the cradle of India's atomic energy programme.

Twenty months before he passed away, he was awarded the Bharat Ratna. In response to a felicitation in March 1992, he said: "An American economist says that in the next century, India will be an economic superpower. I don't want India to be an economic superpower. I want India to be a happy country."

The author is a veteran journalist and has written Beyond the Last Blue Mountain: A Life of J.R.D. Tata



Q: What did his aircraft licence number read?

A: Number 1. His first journey was from India to England in 1930

Q: Which army was he drafted into?

A: The French Army

Q: Born and brought up in France, in which year did he join Tata Sons?

A: He joined Tata Sons as an unpaid apprentice in 1925

Q: What did he make sure to do when at home?

A: Always answer the phone himself

Q: Which firsts did he introduce at Tata Steel?

A: He introduced the eight-hour day, paid leave and provident fund